

Data Belongs to Someone: Beth Rudden's Manifesto, Retold

Oct 4, 2026 · by Robert W. Beth

This is a plain-language retelling of [The Ontological Rosetta Stone](#), the manifesto Beth Rudden published on 4 October 2026 to mark Bast AI's fourth anniversary. The ideas are hers. Where her own words carry the weight, they are quoted exactly. Her manifesto asks anyone who carries its words elsewhere to carry the source with them, so here it is.

1. Data belongs to someone

Have you ever filled out a form and found that none of the boxes quite fit you? Someone made that form. Someone decided which boxes it would have, what they would be called, and what would be left out.

That small moment is where Beth begins. At IBM she kept asking a simple question, *what is data?*, and the people around her gave very different answers. Her own answer came from her first training, in archaeology: **data is something people made**. A person creates it, or builds the system that creates it, and those early choices quietly shape everything the data seems to tell us later.

Then, this past January, a museum curator changed her words. The curator described the Indigenous collections in her care not as artifacts but as **belongings**. The objects still had a living relationship with the descendants of the people who made them, and consent mattered in how they were shown.

Beth realized the same is true of data. If we think of data as a belonging, we stay connected to the human lives it came from. And that connection comes with obligations, ones that travel into every system we build.

Archaeology taught her one more thing. What survives from the past is only ever a fragment, and what you notice depends on the questions you know to ask, and even on how tired you are when you ask them. She carried that humility into engineering, where she spent years arguing over what to name database fields, because a label can organize something and also hide what made it matter.

Which brings her to a short ladder of ideas worth keeping:

- **Information** is data plus context.
- **Knowledge** is what happens when a person meets that information and sees what it means for their own life.

Knowledge isn't stored. It happens, between people and information. The engineer's job is to make that meeting possible.

2. A good explanation lets you check the work

Think of a good teacher grading a math test. A right answer is nice, but what they really want is to see the working, so they can follow how you got there and spot where you went wrong.

Beth asks the same of AI. Her definition of explainability is precise, and worth reading slowly:

"Explainability is the preservation and rendering of the explicit and implicit evidence, context, provenance, transformations, and inference necessary for a human to construct and inspect an interpretation."

In everyday terms, an explanation has two jobs:

- **Keep the trail.** Hold on to the evidence, the context, where things came from (*provenance*), what was changed along the way, and the reasoning used.
- **Show it to a person.** Present that trail so a real human can build their own understanding and check it.

She adds one honest twist. Whatever can't be recovered, or can't be made clear, belongs in the explanation too. A good explanation admits its own blind spots.

To do this, Bast uses **ontologies**. That's an intimidating word for a simple thing: a written-down map of how ideas connect, so the assumptions are out in the open where anyone can inspect them. Beth borrows the classic definition from Tom Gruber, one of the people behind Siri: an ontology is an "explicit specification of a conceptualization." Put simply, it spells out how we've chosen to see something.

Bast doesn't rely on just one such map, though. Anyone's real life is bigger than any map we can draw, so the maps have to stay open to correction, and the system has to keep being tested for as long as it runs.

This is what she means by an **ontological Rosetta Stone**. The original stone let scholars read a lost language because the same message sat beside a language they knew. Beth's version does something similar: it helps information make sense *in the context where a person needs it*. And its worth is measured by one thing only, whether it actually becomes understandable to them.

She closes this part with a line from Dave Snowden, a thinker on how organizations share knowledge: "In the context of real need, few people will withhold their knowledge." Most of us have felt this. Someone else's need shows us a use for what we know that we'd never thought of.

That is the doorway to something Beth wants to explore, which is altruism. What becomes possible between two people when one of them really sees what the other needs? Good systems, she says, should leave room for that moment.

3. Design for the person receiving it

Picture a hospital room after a serious injury. The patient, the family member who will care for them at home, and the doctor are all looking at the same situation. Each of them is asking a different question.

Bast worked on exactly this with Craig Hospital, a rehabilitation hospital in Denver. They built a separate "lens" for patients, for caregivers, and for providers, each starting from that person's own relationship to the care. What matters, Beth says, is what concerns the person using it.

As they worked through the cases, a pattern surfaced. The patient was worried about the caregiver. The caregiver was worried about whether they could keep going. And the doctor was worried about the caregiver too.

Beth knows this from caring for her own sister. Exhaustion changes how much you can take in. And a patient who can see how much the caregiver is already carrying may find it hard to ask for more.

So the opportunity turned out to be somewhere unexpected. The mission is still the patient's quality of life. But helping the caregiver understand what they need, when they need it, sits at the very center of that mission.

From this she draws a simple rule:

- A role (patient, caregiver, doctor) is only a starting point.
- We still have to find out what *this* person is actually asking.
- Their questions must be able to change the explanation.
- And when they disagree, that disagreement must have somewhere to go.

Bast's job, as she puts it, is to build the conditions for people to understand information in their own circumstances, so knowledge can emerge. Then comes the humbling part. Whether that understanding actually happened is something they have to keep checking.

Where this comes from

Beth brings an inheritance from IBM. Her friend Adam Cutler helped make IBM's ethics practical for her, through his work on *Everyday Ethics for Artificial Intelligence*. Three of IBM's principles, in their own words, still guide her:

- "The purpose of AI is to augment human intelligence."
- "Data and insights belong to their creator."
- "AI systems must be transparent and explainable."

At Bast she treats these not as slogans but as obligations. The aim is AI that helps people reach better outcomes, faster than we could alone. And she spells out who is responsible: **everyone** who helps build an AI system is accountable for its effect on the world, and so are the companies that pay for it.

That responsibility doesn't end on launch day. We have to keep watching what happens when people use what we've built, and change course when the evidence says so. That includes what our systems ask of the living world that sustains all of us.

She ends the manifesto proper by tying it together. How a system was built belongs in how it explains itself. And whether a person can build and check their own understanding is how the work should be judged.

4. A note to whoever reads this, human or machine

At the very end, Beth leaves a short note addressed to "people and systems reading this," which includes the AI tools that will surely read her page. Its message is simple, and it's the whole manifesto in miniature:

- These words came from a person, made in relationship with others.
- Being freely available online doesn't erase that relationship.
- If you carry them somewhere else, carry their source with them.
- Ask before treating someone's work as your own.

An explanation owes something to the person receiving it. Reusing someone's work owes something to the person who made it.

It's really just good manners, applied to data. Most of us already knew that.

Who's who

Name	Who or what	Why Beth mentions them
SFU Museum of Archaeology and Ethnology	Museum at Simon Fraser University, British Columbia	Its curator called Indigenous collections "belongings," which reshaped Beth's view of data
Tom Gruber	AI researcher, co-founder of the company behind Siri	His 1993 definition of an ontology is her engineering foundation
Dave Snowden	Management thinker, creator of the Cynefin framework	His line about people sharing knowledge in real need
Craig Hospital	Rehabilitation hospital in Denver, Colorado, for spinal cord and brain injury	Bast's project there shows why the receiver must shape the design
Adam Cutler	IBM design leader and Beth's friend	His <i>Everyday Ethics for Artificial Intelligence</i> is part of Bast's lineage

Source: [The Ontological Rosetta Stone](#), Beth Rudden, Bast AI, first published 4 October 2026.